adding capacity, providing technical assistance, and building out infrastructure on strategic islands. In addition, New Delhi expanded national security adviser consultations with Indian Ocean island countries, and entered into agreements to improve their maritime domain awareness.

The one exception to the flurry of diplomacy, economic engagement, connectivity, and regional integration remained Pakistan. For the first two years of his government, Modi made repeated attempts at engagement with Islamabad, despite continuing Pakistani transgressions. His invitation to Nawaz Sharif to New Delhi in 2014 was met with intensified firing on the Line of Control and Pakistan's insistence on meeting with the Hurriyat, a coalition of Kashmiri separatists. Progress at a July 2015 summit in Ufa in Russia was eroded by Pakistan's cancellation of national security advisor talks. In December 2015, Modi's stopover visit in Lahore on a return to New Delhi from Kabul was followed immediately by a terrorist attack in Pathankot. India's controversial invitation to a Pakistani' Joint Investigative Team (JIT), in the hopes that it would enable reciprocal access to Pakistan, was followed by the detention, trial, and sentencing to death by Pakistan of a former Indian naval officer Kulbhushan Jadhav as an alleged spy. [21]

Relations, already testy, went into deep freeze following the killing in Jammu and Kashmir of Hizbul Mujahideen commander Burhan Wani in July 2016, which triggered wider violence in the Kashmir Valley. Pakistan used these events to once again attempt to internationalize the dispute. Furthermore, a terrorist attack in Uri in September 2016 was followed a ground assault by India on terrorist targets across the Line of Control ('surgical strikes'). Economic relations also remained fraught, with the Pakistan Army preventing Nawaz Sharif from recognizing most favoured nation (MFN) status for India, and Pakistan undermining Afghan and Indian proposals for a collective transit trade agreement. Furthermore, Pakistan's army chief, General Qamar Javed Bajwa, urged that Sikh pilgrims be offered a special corridor to access Kartarpur in Pakistan, an attempt that India believed was intended to fan pro-Khalistan separatist sentiments. [22] Just before the 2019 General Elections, a major terrorist attack on Indian forces in Pulwama led to Indian Air Force strikes at a terrorist training